



Vowel-Team Trails: AI, AY, EE, and EA

Grade 2 • New Jersey • Phonics / spelling

L.RF.2.3

Decode common long-vowel words with ai, ay, ee, and ea. Includes 16 practice tasks, a four-task exit check, two explained models, and complete answer guidance.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan a focused lesson

Level and alignment

Grade 2 • New Jersey • Phonics / spelling; L.RF.2.3. Focus: Decode common long-vowel words with ai, ay, ee, and ea.

What is included

One cover; one teacher guide; one mini-lesson with two explained models; 1 original text/reference section(s); 16 practice tasks on four pages; one four-task exit check; four answer-key pages covering all 20 tasks; two access/source/license pages. Student texts are original, not extracted from released tests.

Time and sequence

Two 30–40-minute sessions plus a 10–15-minute exit check; extended writing or speech rehearsal may take longer. Model first; use tasks 1–4 to check readiness; practice the remainder in short groups; give tasks 17–20 without the key.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from teacher pages. Provide pencils and extra paper; oral-response learners need an adult recorder. Review word meanings and prerequisite decoding or sentence skills. No paid app, novel, or external reading is required.

Student directions

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.



Learn the move

In these examples, ai and ay spell long a; ee and ea spell long e. Underline the team, blend the word, and check its meaning. These patterns are common, not universal: ea in bread has a different sound. Teach the listed patterns explicitly; do not teach “two vowels always say the first vowel’s name.”

Model 1 • Read train; underline the team.

ai spells long a in train; blend the beginning tr and ending n around it.

Model 2 • Read beach; underline the vowel team.

ea spells long e; ch is a separate consonant digraph.

Try the task first. Then compare the reasoning, not just the final word.



Practice bank

ai: rain, mail, tail, paint. ay: day, play, stay, tray. ee: seed, feet, green, sleep. ea: team, leaf, seat, clean. Adult: preteach meanings and consonant clusters as needed, then have learners read the target word independently.



Practice • Read, reason, respond

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.

1. Read rain and day. What vowel sound do they share?

2. Read seed and leaf. What vowel sound do they share?

3. Sort mail, play, paint, stay by vowel team.

4. Sort green, team, feet, seat by vowel team.



Practice • Read, reason, respond

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.

5. Read tail. Change t to m. Read the new word.

6. Read day. Add pl in place of d. Read the new word.

7. Read seed. Change d to m. Read the new word.

8. Read seat. Change t to m. Read the new word.



Practice • Read, reason, respond

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.

9. Complete r__n for water falling from clouds: ai or ee?

10. Complete sl__p for resting at night: ay or ee?

11. Complete l__f for part of a plant: ea or ai?

12. Complete tr__ for something that carries plates: ay or ee?



Practice • Read, reason, respond

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.

13. Read: The green team can play. Find three vowel-team words.

14. Read: I can paint a leaf. Find both vowel-team words.

15. Write a sentence with clean; read it aloud.

16. Does ea always have long e? Use the lesson's exception.



Exit check • Apply the skill

Try without the answer key. Show evidence or reasoning when asked. Use separate paper for longer responses.

17. Read stay and identify its vowel team.

18. Read feet and identify its vowel team.

19. Complete m__l for letters delivered to a home. Read it.

20. Read: The team will stay by the green seat. Sort the team words.



Answers and response criteria

1. Long a; ai/ay spell it here.
2. Long e; ee/ea spell it here.
3. ai: mail, paint. ay: play, stay.
4. ee: green, feet. ea: team, seat.
5. mail; vowel team and long-a sound stay the same.

Accept equivalent correct answers and well-supported interpretations. Sample writing is guidance, not a required script.



Answers and response criteria

6. play.

7. seem; long e remains.

8. seam; long e remains.

9. rain, ai.

10. sleep, ee.

Accept equivalent correct answers and well-supported interpretations. Sample writing is guidance, not a required script.



Answers and response criteria

11. leaf, ea.

12. tray, ay.

13. green (ee), team (ea), play (ay).

14. paint (ai), leaf (ea).

15. Meaningful sentence with clean accurately spelled and decoded.

Accept equivalent correct answers and well-supported interpretations. Sample writing is guidance, not a required script.



Answers and response criteria

16. No. Bread has a different vowel sound.

17. ay; long a.

18. ee; long e.

19. mail, ai.

20. ea: team, seat; ay: stay; ee: green. Read each accurately.

Accept equivalent correct answers and well-supported interpretations. Sample writing is guidance, not a required script.



Access and next teaching steps

AIG

Ask for a counterexample, an alternative supported interpretation, or a newly written item with an explanation. Add depth rather than speed.

504

Follow the individual plan: breaks, enlarged print, extra time, reduced copying, or an alternative response method as documented. These are classroom options, not a statement of permitted test accommodations.

EC

Follow the IEP; show one task at a time, model the first decision, and permit dictated reasoning when appropriate. For decoding practice, distinguish an adult-read direction from an adult-read target word.

ESL

Preview task verbs and key vocabulary, allow home-language planning, and offer “My answer is ___ because ___.” Evaluate the targeted skill separately from unrelated language errors. For French, retain the target French sentence while explaining directions in a familiar language.

Use the exit evidence

For each exit task, record 2 = accurate and complete for the stated prompt; 1 = partly accurate or missing a requested explanation; 0 = not yet demonstrated. Total 0–8 is a local teaching note, not a standardized score. For oral tasks do not penalize spelling or handwriting. Revisit the exact type of error rather than assigning a diagnostic label.

Next lesson: model one missed decision, let the learner try a new example, and compare the explanation. Extend only after the learner can explain the targeted skill.

Alignment, sources, and license

The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the cited standard; this is not a full curriculum or official practice test.

Official state standard • accessed September 15, 2026

<https://www.nj.gov/education/standards/ela/2023/2.shtml>

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